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For Paralympic high jumper Mariyappan Thangavelu, the nerves of competition and the larger challenges of pursuing the sport with a disability sometimes overwhelmed him during the early stages of his career. Furthermore, a passport issue denied him the chance to compete in the London Paralympic Games, complicating an

already difficult journey.

A little over a decade later, Mariyappan — the son of a single mother who worked odd jobs as a bricklayer and vegetable vendor — has earned three Paralympic medals — gold at the Rio Games, silver in Tokyo, and bronze in Paris.

“In Paris, my training was perfect. Even three days before my main event, I was clearing heights of 1.95m (the gold medal-winning jump in Paris was 1.94m),” Mariyappan told *Sportstar*.

The winning combination: The Indian para contingent during a felicitation ceremony organised by IndianOil to honour them for their historic performance at the Paris 2024 Paralympic Games. GETTY IMAGES

“However, just days before my event, I came down with a fever. It rained for a few days in Paris. The cold air and stiffness didn’t allow me to perform a proper free jump,” he added, expressing regret at missing out on gold yet again.